

THE WORDS WE BROUGHT WITH  
US



# THE WORDS WE BROUGHT WITH US

*The words, the sayings, and the songs we still say.*

JOSHUA CALEB GREEN

WORDS TO KEEP

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Everything written into this book by hand, in any language, belongs to the person who wrote it and to whoever they give it to.

This book is meant to be written in. Write in your own alphabet. Spell it the way you say it.

Series: Words to Keep

# If you're giving this book

*Four things that make the difference between a book that fills up and one that doesn't.*

1. Fill in the next page before you wrap it. Say which language, and why you want it kept.
2. At the end of most parts there's a page called A question from your family. Write on each one a word you half-remember and want back.
3. Ask them, out loud, the first time you're together: "What did your mother call you when you were in trouble?" Write the answer on the spot, in the book.
4. Read it back to them, badly. Being corrected is half the point.

This book was given to

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BY

ON

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Because

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*If you bought this book for yourself:*

This book belongs to

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# The words are yours.

Someone gave you this book because there are words only you still say. The thing your mother shouted from the kitchen. The name for the soft part of the bread. The song you sang without knowing you were singing. The word that means "I'm tired, but happy, and a little sad, and it's evening," that has no English.

They've heard you say these things their whole lives. They can't say them back. In a generation, nobody will.

This book is for those words. Not the language, all of it. Just the part that lived in your house.

Write them the way you say them. Spell them however you like, in whichever alphabet you like. Put the meaning underneath, and when you said it, and who said it best. There's a line on every entry for the person learning it to write how it sounds to them. Let them. Correct them. That's the whole exercise.

Start with your name.

# How to use this book

Any language. Any alphabet. Any spelling, as long as it's how you say it.

Two words to a page, in Part Two. Fifty-two in all. If you have more, there's an index at the back with room to keep going.

Every entry has a line for the person learning the word to write how it sounds to them. It will be wrong. Leave it. Write the right way underneath.

Where the book says mother, father, or home, it means whoever and wherever that was for you.

Write in pen. Cross things out. The mistakes are part of the record.

If writing is hard, say the word and let someone write it. Or record it on a phone and write on the page where the recording is kept. The sound of you saying it is the thing.

# The rules

*There aren't any, except these:*

If you're not sure how to spell it, spell it how you say it.

If it's rude, it counts. Especially if it's rude.

If it's a word your family made up, it counts more.

If you can't remember the word but you remember when it was said, write that.



## PART ONE

# How to say my name

Every word in this book starts here. The name you were given, the name they called you, and the way your name changed when it crossed over.

Then the names of the people you're writing this for, the way you say them.

My name

WRITTEN, THE WAY IT'S WRITTEN AT HOME

SAID, THE WAY IT'S SAID AT HOME

## WHAT IT MEANS, OR WHO I'M NAMED AFTER

## WHAT THEY CALLED ME AS A CHILD

WHAT MY NAME BECAME HERE, AND WHAT I THINK OF THAT

# Your names, in my language

*For each person this book is for. Their name, and the way I say it.*

NAME, AND HOW I SAY IT

NAME, AND HOW I SAY IT

NAME, AND HOW I SAY IT

NAME, AND HOW I SAY IT

WHAT I'D HAVE NAMED YOU, IF IT HAD BEEN UP TO ME

# Where the language comes from

## THE COUNTRY, THE REGION, THE TOWN

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HOW WE SPEAK IT DIFFERENTLY FROM THE REST OF THEM

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WHO TAUGHT IT TO ME

---

## WHO I STILL SPEAK IT WITH

[illegible]

# Who spoke it to me

MY MOTHER, AND HOW SHE SPOKE

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MY FATHER, AND HOW HE SPOKE

---

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THE ONE WHO SPOKE IT MOST BEAUTIFULLY

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---

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THE ONE WHO SWORE IN IT

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# Quick ones

The first word I'd teach a baby.

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The word I say without thinking, even in English.

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The word I've forgotten and want back.

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What we call the television.

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What we call a fool, affectionately.

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---

---

The word for the feeling of coming home.

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## A question from your family.

*Written by the person who gave you this book.*

## THEIR QUESTION

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.



## PART TWO

# The words we still use

Fifty-two of them, two to a page. Not the whole language. The part that lived in the house.

The word. How to say it. What it means. When we said it, and who said it best. And a line for the one learning it to write how it sounds to them.

THE WORD

HOW TO SAY IT

WHAT IT MEANS

WHEN WE SAID IT, AND WHO SAID IT BEST

HOW IT SOUNDS TO ME (FOR THE ONE LEARNING IT)

THE WORD

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HOW IT SOUNDS TO ME (FOR THE ONE LEARNING IT)

# Quick ones

The word for the soft part of the bread.

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The word for the thing you use to stir.

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---

The word for a person who talks too much.

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What we say when someone sneezes.

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What we say when a glass breaks.

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---

The word for the last bit of food nobody wants to take.

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## A question from your family.

*Written by the person who gave you this book.*

## THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]



PART THREE

# Things my mother shouted from the kitchen

The words that came with a tone. What she called you when you were in trouble. What she said at the door. The blessings, the curses, the jokes that don't survive translation.

These are the ones that go first, because nobody writes them down. Write them down.

What she called us when we were in trouble.

*The whole sentence, with the name in it.*

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[illegible]

[illegible]

# What my father said instead.

*His words. His tone. The one he saved for special occasions.*

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The blessings.

*Before a meal, before a journey, over a child's head.*

[illegible]

# The curses. The mild ones.

*The ones you can say in front of the children, and what they actually mean.*

[illegible]

# The jokes that only work in our language.

*Tell one anyway, and explain why it's funny. It won't be. That's fine.*

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A word we have that English doesn't.

*Say what it means the long way.*

[illegible]

[illegible]

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- How we say I love you.

*And how often, and whether we said it at all, and what we said instead.*

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# Finish these, in our language

Come here, I said

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Eat.

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What did I tell you

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Good night

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---

God help me

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Don't make me

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## A question from your family.

*Written by the person who gave you this book.*

## THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]



## PART FOUR

# The songs

The lullaby. The one for parties. The one from the old country that everyone knew and nobody could translate. The hymn, if there was one.

Write the words the way you sang them, wrong words included. The tune is in your head; write the name of it, or who sang it on the radio, so someone can find it.

The one you sang to us as babies

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one for parties

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

The one from the old country that everyone knew

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one for a wedding

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one for a funeral

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

*Only if there was one.*

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

[illegible]

# The one from the radio when I was young

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

## WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one my mother sang while she worked

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one I sing without noticing

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one I want sung for me

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

# The one everyone knows the words to

*Write all of it. Every verse. This is the one they'll need.*

TITLE, OR THE FIRST LINE

WHO SANG IT, AND WHEN

THE WORDS, AS WE SANG THEM

## A question from your family.

*Written by the person who gave you this book.*

## THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]



PART FIVE

# The food, by its real name

Nobody in our family ever called it by the English name. Write the real ones, and what we ate on which day, and what we said before and after.

# Dishes, and what we called them

*The dish, in our language. What it is, in English, as close as you can get.*

|          |               |
|----------|---------------|
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
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| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |

# More dishes

|          |               |
|----------|---------------|
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
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| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |
| THE WORD | WHAT IT MEANS |
| <hr/>    | <hr/>         |

# The recipe

*One recipe, in our language, in your handwriting. Include the part that isn't written down anywhere.*

WHAT IT'S CALLED

---

WHO TAUGHT IT TO ME

---

WHAT GOES IN IT

---

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# What we said at the table

BEFORE EATING

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---

---

WHEN IT WAS GOOD

---

---

---

WHEN SOMEONE COOKED BADLY, AND WE WERE BEING KIND

---

---

---

WHEN THERE WASN'T ENOUGH, AND WE PRETENDED THERE WAS

---

---

---

THE THING WE ALWAYS SAID TO A GUEST

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---

# Quick ones

The dish for a birthday.

---

---

---

The dish for a death.

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---

---

The dish for a cold.

---

---

---

The thing we ate that nobody else's family ate.

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---

---

The word for "seconds."

---

---

---

What we drank, and what we called it.

---

---

---



PART SIX

# Letters, in both languages

Write to them in your language first. Then write it again in English, or as close as you can get. Then leave them room to write back.

The two letters won't match. That's the point.

# A letter to you, in my language

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

# The words I want you to keep

*Ten words. If you keep nothing else, keep these.*

ONE

---

---

TWO

---

---

THREE

---

---

FOUR

---

---

FIVE

---

---

SIX

---

---

SEVEN

---

---

EIGHT

---

---

NINE

---

---

TEN

---

---



## One last thing to say, in our language

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

## For the one reading this

*Someone wrote these words down because they were the last one who  
said them. Say them out loud. Say them wrong. Say them to a child.  
That's how they stayed alive this long.*

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